

THE AMERICAS

Rather than helping hard-pressed journalists, authorities are threatening them

Press freedom in the Americas has continued to deteriorate, falling 14 points in the World Press Freedom Index since 2022 — the same downward trend seen in the world's two most difficult regions for journalism, Eastern Europe and Central Asia (EECA) and the Middle East and North Africa (MENA).

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Journalism in this zone has long been strained due to the economic fragility of the media market and, in Latin America, persistent violence against the press. Now, in 2026, there is a marked trend of authorities across the region adding to these pressures through hostile rhetoric, legal and administrative constraints, restricted access to public information and the instrumentalisation of legal systems to quash reporting. Journalism is being criminalised, muzzled by gag lawsuits and, in countries plagued by cartel violence, made ever more dangerous by the lack of protection for news workers.

In the **United States** (which ranks 64th out of 180 countries and territories) journalists who were already fighting against economic headwinds and dealing with a crisis of public trust — among other challenges — now also contend with President Donald Trump's systematic weaponisation of state institutions, including funding cuts to public broadcasters such as *NPR* and *PBS*, political interference in media ownership, and politically motivated investigations targeting disfavoured journalists and media outlets. Since his return to office,

journalists have also been targeted on the ground during protests, reflecting a broader deterioration that amounts to one of the most severe crises for press freedom in modern US history.

Argentina (98th) dropped 11 positions in 2026 under Trump ally President Javier Milei, and has fallen more than 69 spots in the Index since 2022 due to increased institutional hostility towards the press and violence towards journalists covering protests. **El Salvador** (143rd, -8 places in 2026) has also continued its downward trend, dropping 74 places since President Nayib Bukele, another leader aligned with Trump, came into power in 2019. His government stepped up its criminalisation of journalism, notably through the 2025 [foreign agents law](#), which requires individuals and organisations that receive foreign funding to pay a 30 per cent tax on that income and grants the government sweeping powers to suspend or dissolve entities deemed non-compliant. In practice, it serves as a direct tool for silencing dissent and, combined with abusive lawsuits, has driven dozens of journalists into exile in a matter of months.

In countries plagued by cartel violence, like **Mexico** (122nd), there is a drastic need for strong protection to keep the press safe — yet the authorities in many of these states are making matters worse. **Ecuador** (125th), which has seen the region's sharpest fall (-31), is facing an unprecedented erosion in journalists' safety as violence linked to organised crime spreads and increasingly hostile public officials increase pressure on the press. This is also the case in **Peru** (144th, -14), where four journalists

independent media outlets.

Worryingly, some of these trends resemble more traditional forms of censorship — state crackdowns and direct attacks — that prevail in countries such as **Nicaragua** (168nd), **Cuba** (160th) and **Venezuela** (159th), where press freedom remains at its lowest levels in the region.

Conversely, some countries show signs of improvement or relative stability. **Brazil** (52nd) has gained 58 positions since 2022. **Colombia** (102nd) and **Uruguay** (48th) recorded improvements, as did **Guatemala** (128th), despite the ongoing persecution of journalists like Jose Rubén Zamora. **Canada** (20th) has become the regional leader as a result of **Trinidad & Tobago's** (32nd) decline, which was driven in part by worsening economic and political conditions. RSF noted a similar trend in **Belize** (66th), where journalists' discontent with their working conditions is growing.